to give way. Weighed against all of these responsibilities, the jewel in the crown of the British Empire, India, would have to be abandoned.

This panoply of events on the world stage proved to be too much of a burden for Attlee's government and they decided to find a candidate for Viceroy of India; someone who would replace Wavell and handle the winding up of the British Raj in India. Attlee offered the job to King George VI's cousin, Lord Louis Mountbatten. No historian has provided a plausible reason for this appointment. Mountbatten had always dreamt of serving as First Sea Lord of the Royal Navy[5], a post he took charge of, in 1955, and held for four years. In Britain's naval history, Mountbatten and his father were the only father and son duo to ever serve on this post. Till his retirement in 1965, Mountbatten served as the UK's Chief of Defence Staff. He was the longest-serving professional military officer in the British armed forces.[6]

No historian has examined whether Churchill, Ismay and Cunningham influenced Attlee in his decision to appoint Mountbatten, who was a member of the British royal family and a former commander of British forces in South-east Asia, as the last Viceroy of India.[7] Could this task have been entrusted to a safer pair of hands? Was there anyone safer than a member of the British royal family and a distinguished military man to handle this delicate task? Did Churchill brief Mountbatten before he accepted the job? Was Lord Ismay's appointment as Mountbatten's Chief of Staff, Churchill's idea? Was Ismay Churchill's way of making sure that Mountbatten toed the Churchillian line to the hilt?

Mountbatten Opens His Account

Mountbatten arrived in India to take over as the Viceroy, on 22 March 1947. By this time, the Government of India had a clear idea as to what Maharaja Hari Singh intended to do after the transfer of power in June 1948. If possible, he would prefer to opt for independence from India.[8] He already had bad blood with Nehru, and Sheikh Abdullah continued to be a thorn in